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Internal Colonization. Russia's Imperial Experience by Alexander Etkind (review)

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Russian rule.⁵ But such comparisons, important as they are for scholarship of the future, would still leave unaccomplished the task of clearly defining the geography traversed by the genres, texts, and cultures of circulation studied in Manning's work. The future of Caucasus Studies is at stake in the determinations that are made with respect to Manning's geography, and, once that determination is made, there is no doubting that Manning's achievement will be a foundation stone in the eventual field that his work is helping to constitute.



Alexander MORRISON

Alexander Etkind, *Internal Colonization. Russia's Imperial Experience* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2011) ix + 289 pp., ill. Index. ISBN: 978-0-7456-5130-9.

This is an important and stimulating, but flawed book. It consists of a series of essays in cultural history and literary criticism, which Etkind describes as “a kind of Eisensteinian *montage* interwoven with an overarching principle, which in this book is internal colonization” (P. 2). He argues that the internal colonization of Russia by its own state, and the relationship between Russia's literate elites and its masses in the post-Petrine period, are comparable to the external colonization of Asia, Africa, and America by European states and by Russia itself, and can thus be interpreted through a post-colonial lens. He also states at the outset that “this book is a project in Cultural Studies” (P. 3). Both these statements rendered this reviewer apprehensive – the first because the language of postcolonialism frequently mistakes opacity for pro-

⁵ A productive line of inquiry in this regard would be with the emergence of Hindi print culture, which coincided in many respects with the emergence of Georgian print culture, and under similarly fraught, and colonially inflected, conditions. On this topic, see Ulrike Starke. *An Empire of Books: The Naval Kishore Press and the Diffusion of the Printed Word in Colonial India, 1858–1895*. New Delhi, 2007, and, for a slightly later period, Francesca Orsini. *The Hindi Public Sphere 1920–1940: Language and Literature in the Age of Nationalism*. Oxford, 2002.

fundity, the second because all too often “Cultural Studies” is shorthand for saying more and more about less and less, or an excuse for writing history without doing any research. In fact Etkind’s book does not fall into either of these traps. His writing is admirably clear and elegant throughout (apart from the grating use of “Brits” where he means “British,”¹ and some unfortunate typographical errors),² and while the book is not a piece of original research, he has read very widely in literature, literary criticism, and historiography, bringing new insights to well-known texts, and unearthing others that are much more obscure. Some of the essays in *Internal Colonization* are individually brilliant, but Etkind’s “overarching principle” is both too weak and too problematic to bind them together effectively.

Etkind bases his initial argument on the idea that internal and external colonization exist simultaneously and are equivalent categories in the Russian context (Pp. 2-6, 19, 251). He never defines either of them geographically, and thus internal colonization sometimes seems to refer only to the core (or “heartland,” as he calls them), European Russian areas of the Empire, at others to regions with large non-Russian

populations, such as Bashkiria, Siberia, and the European steppe. But can the colonial violence that led to the near extermination of so many Siberian peoples, or the relationship between Russian administrators and Muslim subjects in Central Asia, really be equated to the extension of the state’s control over ethnic Russians in the empire’s heartland, or the relationship between Russia’s elites and its peasantry? Is “internal colonization” really a useful term to describe the latter? I am doubtful.

Etkind describes the concept of internal colonization as “an old, well-tested tool of knowledge,” but the intellectual genealogy he gives it is somewhat confused. On the one hand, he traces it back to certain unspecified nineteenth-century German authors, and, in the Russian context, to Afanasii Shchapov (Pp. 6-8), while he writes that his use of it is taken from the work of Jürgen Habermas. However the book opens (P. 2) with the famous quotation from the historian Sergei Solov’ev, popularized by his pupil Vasilii Kliuchevskii: “The history of Russia is the history of a country which colonizes itself,”³ and Etkind discusses the genesis of this idea in Imperial Russian historiography very effectively in Chapter 4 (“To Colonize

¹ It is just possible that Etkind intends this as a pun on *brityi chelovek* or “shaved man,” the term he uses for members of Russia’s ruling elite.

² “Caucuses” for “Caucasus” and “canon” for “cannon” are found throughout.

³ V. I. Kliuchevskii. *Kurs russkoi istorii*. Part 1. Moscow, 1911. Pp. 24-25.

Oneself,” Pp. 61-71). It seems to me that when Solov’ev and Kliuchevskii used the reflexive form of what was then a novel verb in Russian (*kolonizuietsia*), they were not referring to the alienation of the state and its elites from their “own” people, nor were they referring to the extension of coercive and governmental control over that people by the state (even if Kliuchevskii did think that process was taking place at the same time; P. 70). They were referring to the process of settlement – of the migration of the Russian population into lands that were sometimes more or less “empty,” but normally had previously been inhabited by other peoples, who were then dispossessed and sometimes exterminated.⁴ These regions were then incorporated into the Russian state, though not always on terms of political equality. This is made quite explicit by Kliuchevskii, who immediately after this famous line writes:

The field of colonization in her broadened together with her state territory [...] from here the population moved in many-sided streams to New Russia [i.e., the Black Sea Steppes], to the

Caucasus, beyond the Volga and further to the Caspian, especially to the Urals and Siberia, to the shores of the Pacific ocean. In the second half of the 19th century, when the Russian colonization of Turkestan had just begun, more than 200,000 Russians had already been introduced there.⁵

Nineteenth-century Russian historians may not have referred to Poland or Finland as colonies (these were not destinations for Russian settlement anyway) but the European and Asian steppes, Siberia, and Central Asia certainly were considered to be “external” objects of colonization, even if the long-term goal was their absorption into Russia. This story – the actual process of Russian colonization of lands that had formerly been inhabited by others – is almost entirely absent from Etkind’s book. By the late nineteenth century, it had translated into a full-blown ideology of colonization that gave ethnic Russians a preeminent right to the empire’s land at the expense of non-Russian (usually Turkic, nomadic, and Muslim) populations.⁶ For the reader to

⁴ Regarding Solov’ev this point is made quite clearly by Mark Bassin in an article that Etkind cites. See Mark Bassin. Turner, Solov’ev, and the “Frontier Hypothesis”. The Nationalist Signification of Open Spaces // *Journal of Modern History*. 1993. Vol. 65. No. 3. Pp. 495-500.

⁵ Kliuchevskii. *Kurs russkoi istorii*. Part 1. P. 25.

⁶ See, for example, P. P. Semenov. *Znachenie Rossii v kolonizatsionnom dvizhenii evropeiskikh narodov* // *Izvestiia Imperatorskogo Russkogo Geograficheskogo Obshchestva*.

gauge whether the vocabulary of “internal colonization” and “external colonization” is appropriate to Russia’s imperial experience, we need examples from both, not just the former, and a clear definition of where Etkind thinks each applies.

I will return to this theme later in the review, but first it seems only just to explore the many insights of some of the individual chapters in this book: Etkind’s strengths lie in close textual analysis (where his frame of reference is much wider than that usually applied to Russian literature and history) and in prosopography, as he identifies hitherto unsuspected links between historical figures.

Chapters 1 and 2 (“Less than One and Double” and “Worldliness,” Pp. 13–42) offer a sort of *amuse-bouche* of postcolonial theory applied to a series of Russian imperial texts and situations, beginning with Gogol’s *Nose* (where Etkind uses Homi Bhabha’s concept of “colonial doubling”), and taking us through a comparison of Uvarov and Macaulay’s educational policies, Gramsci, Arendt and the “boomerang” effect of the reimportation of colonial violence and practices to the metropole,

the little-known second volume of Defoe’s *Robinson Crusoe*, with its Russian and Siberian themes (of which Etkind gives a fine exegesis), Kipling’s “Ballad of East and West” (where he recognizes the ambiguities that lie behind the apparent clarity of the opening line), and Edward Said’s uncle, Charles Malik. If there is perhaps an element of what Terry Eagleton called the “gaudy, all-licensed supermarket of the mind” in all this,⁷ as cultural references are plucked off the shelf seemingly at random, Etkind does successfully make the point that (a) Russia and the “Second World” crop up in the most unexpected texts and contexts that have been subject to “mainstream” postcolonial analysis (*Robinson Crusoe*, Said’s anticommunist uncle), but have been consistently overlooked, and (b) postcolonial criticism can shed new light on apparently “domestic” Russian literature and Russian history.

Chapter 5 (“Barrels of Fur,” Pp. 72–90) is a lucid account of the consequences of resource dependency for the development of the Russian state, drawing compelling parallels between fur in the early modern

1892. Vol. XXVIII. Pp. 358–359; see further Willard Sunderland. The Ministry of Asiatic Russia: The Colonial Office That Never Was but Might Have Been // *Slavic Review*. 2010. Vol. 69. No. 1. Pp. 120–150; Alexander Morrison. Sowing the Seed of National Strife in This Alien Region. The Pahlen Report and Pereselenie in Turkestan 1908–1910 // *Acta Slavica Iaponica*. 2012. Vol. 31. Pp. 1–29.

⁷ Terry Eagleton. In the Gaudy Supermarket // *London Review of Books*. 1999. Vol. 21. No. 10. May 13. Pp. 3–6, available at: <http://www.lrb.co.uk/v21/n10/terry-eagleton/in-the-gaudy-supermarket> (last accessed October 23, 2013).

period and oil in contemporary Russia. It is marred by a slight naivety regarding sources – I am not sure Kennan's late nineteenth-century account is reliable evidence for Chukchi trading practices 200 years earlier (P. 75). It is also unfortunate that Etkind overextends his argument to suggest that just as Siberia was conquered for fur, Transcaucasia and Central Asia were annexed for, respectively, silk and cotton (P. 90). This is simply a repetition of a Soviet-era canard regarding the economic roots of nineteenth-century Russian imperial expansion, which ultimately derives from Lenin and, through him, J. A. Hobson.⁸ There is in fact no evidence that economic motives played any part in these annexations, which were determined by imperial prestige, personal ambition, and military imperatives.⁹

In Chapter 6 ("Occult Instability," Pp. 93-122) Etkind explores the paradox that Russians (or at least members of the Russian elite), while they had fewer qualms about racial difference and mixing than British or French imperial rulers, could feel so distant and alienated from their "own" peasantry. "In a society of

internal colonization that had annexed, absorbed and exterminated its others, almost everyone was of one and the same color. To play the function of race, this society created estates" (P. 93). This assumption that the religious or racial "other" had always been absorbed or exterminated is questionable (a theme I will return to below), but necessary to Etkind's argument that social categories could play the same role in creating "difference." Bringing in comparisons from New Zealand to Holland, exploring the case of Abram Gannibal, Pushkin's black ancestor, and the cultural hybridity that emerged in eighteenth- and early nineteenth-century Yakutia, the chapter concludes with a highly original interpretation of firework displays as "means of hegemony." In textual terms, Etkind focuses on Lermontov and Griboedov, successfully highlighting the unease the former felt at evidence of cultural mingling with the "Orient." Griboedov's sense of distance from the peasant culture of Pargolovo, a suburb of St. Petersburg, his description of a picnic there as a journey to an exotic land, is certainly striking. I wonder, though,

⁸ J. A. Hobson. *Imperialism: A Study*. London, 1902; A. M. Eckstein. Is there a "Hobson–Lenin Thesis" on Late Nineteenth-Century Colonial Expansion? // *Economic History Review*. 1991. Vol. 44. No. 2. Pp. 306-307.

⁹ David MacKenzie. *Expansion in Central Asia: St. Petersburg vs. The Turkestan Generals (1863–1866)* // *Canadian Slavic Studies*. 1969. Vol. 3. No. 2. Pp. 286-311; Seymour Becker. *Russia's Protectorates in Central Asia. Bukhara and Khiva 1865–1924*. Cambridge, MA, 1968. Pp. 1-45; Moshe Gammer. *Muslim Resistance to the Tsar. Shamil and the Conquest of Chechnya and Daghestan*. London, 1994.

if more comparisons cannot be found in other European cultures: Carlo Levi's *Christ Stopped at Eboli* certainly sprang to my mind. I am also skeptical as to whether that sense of difference is properly described as "colonial" – the language of class and social difference, whether drawn from Marx, Weber, or Thompson, would surely be more appropriate.¹⁰ Finally, while Etkind acknowledges that Russian writers, especially Slavophiles such as Khomiakov (cited on P. 120) and Danilevskii (who curiously does not figure anywhere in the book) claimed that "as an imperial nation, Russians possess a uniquely cosmopolitan, universal comprehension" (P. 119), he does not explore the way in which this claim to tolerance and kinship, rather than "difference," was used as a legitimizing discourse for Russian colonialism, one that persisted well into the Soviet era in the form of *Druzhba Narodov*.

Chapter 7 ("Disciplinary Gears," Pp. 122-149) examines the institution of serfdom, the peasant commune, German colonies on the Volga and the Black Sea steppes, Bentham's panopticon, and the "military colonies" of Alexander I.

All of these are used to illustrate the political exclusion of Russians, and the disciplinary and surveillance functions of a state that to most of them was an external force, but Etkind's argument is oversimplified, and does not take into account the powerful reimagining of the Russian nation that took place during the period of the Great Reforms,¹¹ something that did have some real political consequences. Etkind states that "The Russian empire demonstrated a reversed imperial gradient," in that the non-Russian peripheries were more prosperous and enjoyed greater privileges than the Russian center (Pp. 143-144, 252). This is possibly true in fiscal terms (Ekaterina Pravilova's work suggests that in the nineteenth century every non-Russian province other than Poland was a net recipient of revenue),¹² but misleading in almost every other respect. Etkind states that "only Russians and some other Eastern Slavs were subjected to serfdom" – this is incorrect, as the Baltic peoples and some Tatars and Bashkirs were also enserfed, albeit usually by their own nobility – indeed he has contradicted this statement himself earlier (P. 125). He states that "the

¹⁰ E. P. Thompson. *The Making of the English Working Class*. London, 1962.

¹¹ Olga Maiorova. *From the Shadow of Empire. Defining the Russian Nation through Cultural Mythology, 1855–1870*. Madison, WI, 2010. Pp. 5-15.

¹² Ekaterina Pravilova. "Tsena" imperii: tsentr i okrainy v rossiiskom biudzhete v XIX – nachale XX vv. // *Ab Imperio*. 2002. No. 4. Pp. 115-144; Eadem. *Finansy imperii: den'gi i vlast' v politike Rossii na natsional'nykh okrainakh, 1801–1917*. Moscow, 2006.

emancipation began with reforms at the periphery of the empire” (by which he means the Baltic region): this is true, but overlooks the fact that all the other Great Reforms were only applied in the Russian “core,” meaning that Ukraine and the Western Borderlands, Siberia, Central Asia, and the Caucasus were all denied *zemstva*, independent civilian courts, and, later, equal representation in the Duma (where the franchise was deliberately rigged to exclude Muslims).¹³ These latter three regions remained under military rule until 1917, by which time they were being conceived of quite differently from *Korennnaia Rossiia*, as colonies ripe for exploitation for the benefit of the center, although this initially manifested itself in the rapid growth of peasant resettlement rather than higher taxation.¹⁴ As for the economic relationship between European Russia and its peripheries, there has been too little research on this subject for any definite conclusions to be possible, but it seems quite likely that the possession of the Baltic region, Poland, Western Ukraine, and oil-rich Baku, at least, were of net benefit to the imperial “core.” There was a late-imperial

discourse suggesting that the non-Russian nationalities were overprivileged and cosseted at the expense of Russians, but this cannot be taken at face value, as Etkind does here.¹⁵ However, if the economic arguments are inconclusive, the political situation after the 1860s is quite clear: there was a growing distinction between a core Russian region under civilian rule with certain political privileges, and an “Asiatic” empire under military rule where these privileges were not extended. Etkind’s failure to recognize this is a serious flaw.

Chapter 8 (“Internal Affairs,” Pp. 150-169) is perhaps the best in the book, as Etkind delicately traces an intellectual and prosopographical history of the Ministry of Internal Affairs, noting that the roll call of authors and intellectuals who worked there between the 1840s and 1870s far outshines Russian university faculties of the same period. The remarkable linked careers of the Perovskii brothers, illegitimate sons of Count A. K. Razumovskii, comprised between them a minister of internal affairs, a governor-general of Orenburg, a governor of Crimea (whose granddaughter,

¹³ Alexander Morrison. *Metropole, Colony and Imperial Citizenship in the Russian Empire* // *Kritika*. 2012. Vol. 13. No. 2. Pp. 336-351.

¹⁴ Sunderland. *The Ministry of Asiatic Russia; David Mackenzie. Turkestan’s Significance to Russia 1850–1917* // *Russian Review*. 1974. Vol. 35. Pp. 167-188.

¹⁵ See, for example, M. A. Miropiev. *O polozenii russkikh inorodtsev*. St. Petersburg, 1901. Pp. 193-199. See further M. Batunskii. *Rossiia i Islam*. Moscow, 2003. Vol. II. Pp. 242-60, 323-372.

Sofia, organized the assassination of Alexander II), a prolific writer, and a tutor to Alexander III. These family connections were reinforced by intellectual ones, notably personified in the great lexicographer Vladimir Dal', who having served as V. A. Perovskii's secretary in Orenburg (where he wrote most of his dictionary and took part in the disastrous winter expedition to Khiva in 1839), moved to St. Petersburg to serve under Lev Perovskii at the Ministry of Internal Affairs. The Orientalist V. A. Grigor'ev also followed this trajectory from colonial to domestic administration, and Et-kind's suggestion is that neither man saw any great distinction between the two. Grigor'ev certainly saw the Kazakhs (Et-kind unfortunately refers to them throughout the book as "Kyrgyz," evidently not realizing that in the nineteenth century the Russians invariably referred to Kazakhs as "Kirgiz" to avoid confusion with *Kazak* – Cossack) as barbarous in a fairly conventional Orientalist manner, and might have used similar language to describe the Ukrainians (though not, apparently, Russians). Such comparisons of the domestic lower orders with colonized populations overseas were hardly unknown in the Brit-

ish or French case either. Equally, instances abound of colonial techniques of governance, policing, and war being brought "home" to the metropole in other empires, most famously fingerprinting and bombing, while MI5 was established during World War I by former Indian police officers applying colonial surveillance techniques to the domestic public – once again I do not think that this is best described as "internal colonization."¹⁶

Chapter 9 ("Philosophy under Russian Rule," Pp. 173-193) is an excursus on the Russian occupation of Königsberg and East Prussia between 1758 and 1762, demonstrating (convincingly in my view) the considerable impact this brief experience of colonization had on the writings of Kant (who published nothing except some works on earthquakes during the period of Russian rule) and his pupil Herder. This is presumably something Et-kind would characterize as a case of *external* colonization, although he does not specify as such, and it helps to reaffirm one of his central arguments, which is that Russia and the second world usually get left out of "mainstream" European intellectual history, particularly when colonialism is being discussed.

¹⁶ Chandak Sengoopta. *Imprint of the Raj. How Fingerprinting Was Born in Colonial India*. London, 2003; Martin Thomas. *Empires of Intelligence. Security Services and Colonial Disorder after 1914*. Berkeley, CA, 2007; Sven Lindquist. *A History of Bombing*. London, 2012.

Chapter 10 ("Sects and Revolution," Pp. 194-213) revives what has become a rather unfashionable topic among historians of the Russian Empire in recent years, namely, the "Roots of Revolution" in the Populist movement, which Etkind (correctly) sees as intimately bound up with the fascination that Russian sects and schismatics held for radical intellectuals, who saw their religious dissent as resistance to the state and the elite social order. I am not sure I would agree, however, that historians have "neglected" the religious element of "the going to the people movement," or Populism more generally, as Etkind claims (P. 205). Certainly, Venturi wrote extensively about this (and also attributed particular importance to Shchapov),¹⁷ although there is perhaps a lack of connection between the extensive recent historiography on Russian sects, and the older tradition of political and revolutionary history.

Chapter 11 ("Re-enchanting the Darkness," Pp. 214-247) contains a brilliant and moving comparison of Conrad's *Heart of Darkness* and Leskov's *The Enchanted Wanderer*, linking the two through river transport, colonialism, and the unexpected Russian motifs that appear in Conrad. Fliagin, the chief protagonist of Leskov's story (which contains one

of the few descriptions of Central Asian nomadic life within the canon of Russian literature) is characterized by Etkind as "both a witness to *and* an agent of colonialism, Marlow *and* Kurtz in one person" (P. 230), an insight that enriches our understanding of both texts. The minister of Internal Affairs, Lev Perovskii, makes another appearance here, as he had employed Leskov to escort a bargeload of peasants to his new estates in the South (Pp. 224-226). This episode, which culminated in Leskov's imprisonment by a false policeman, is also the image with which Etkind chooses to end the book (P. 256), and is a fine example of Etkind's skill in drawing personal and intellectual connections across the vast spaces of the Russian Empire.

Throughout this tour of eighteenth- and nineteenth-century Russian culture, references to Foucault, Said, Bhabha, Spivak, and other luminaries of postcolonialism are common, but Etkind is never slavish or uncritical in his use of their ideas. He echoes Vera Tolz's criticism of Said's willful ignoring of Russian Orientalism, but where Tolz concentrates specifically on Said's failure to realize the late tsarist origins of much of his attack on the discipline of Oriental Studies,¹⁸ Etkind's point

¹⁷ Franco Venturi. *Roots of Revolution. A History of the Populist and Socialist Movements in 19th Century Russia*. London, 2001 [1957]. Pp. 114-118, 196-203.

¹⁸ Vera Tolz. *European, National and (Anti-) Imperial. The Formation of Academic Oriental Studies in late Tsarist and Early Soviet Russia* // *Kritika*. 2008. Vol. 9. No. 1. Pp. 78-80.

is a broader one, namely, that Said's concentration on relations between the West and the Third World led him to ignore the "Second World" completely (Pp. 39-42), and blinded him to, for instance, the importance of Imperial Russia as a looming, threatening presence in Conrad's writing: this awareness, together with the illuminating comparisons to Leskov, help to make Etkind's own interpretation of *Heart of Darkness* vastly more insightful than Said's narrow, reductive reading of this text.¹⁹ However, Etkind shares with Said a major failing, namely, the almost exclusive focus in both *Orientalism* and *Culture and Imperialism* on what Said called "The Great Cultural Archive."²⁰ Said was a literary scholar, and rarely ventured beyond the established canon of European literature. In *Orientalism* he wrote about Flaubert not because Flaubert was important in the history of nineteenth-century European representations of the Orient (the *Egyptian Letters*, which were Said's focus, were not even published until the 1960s) but because of Flaubert's status as a great nineteenth-century

novelist. In a powerful and convincing critique of *Orientalism* (which Etkind does not cite), Aijaz Ahmad argued that Said's aim was to write a "dark" version of Erich Auerbach's *Mimesis*, where the golden thread of European civilization and culture that Auerbach traced from Ancient Greece to the twentieth century was replaced by the "Original Sin" of Orientalism.²¹ This explains why "great" literature and academic orientalism served Said's polemical purposes better than popular genres, film, or television (all of which would have been better targets in terms of their mindless reproduction of Orientalist tropes).²² Etkind writes, "I take courage in the idea that high literature and culture in Russia played significant roles in the political process" (P. 3), but this is true primarily of revolutionary politics, much less so of the day-to-day activity of the Russian state and its ruling elites. The painful ambiguities of identity and sense of alienation from the Russian *narod*, which were the stock-in-trade of so much Russian elite writing did not necessarily find echoes further

¹⁹ Edward W. Said. *Culture and Imperialism*. London, 1993. P. xxiii.

²⁰ Said claims that Conrad portrays the "redemptive force" of the European presence, and that the novella is largely concerned with "Europeans performing acts of imperial mastery and will in (or about) Africa," a crass misreading by someone who wrote his first monograph on Conrad: Said. *Culture and Imperialism*. P. 25.

²¹ Aijaz Ahmad. *Orientalism and After // In Theory: Classes, Nations, Literatures*. London, 1992. Pp. 159-219.

²² Robert Irwin. *For Lust of Knowing. The Orientalists and Their Enemies*. London, 2006. Pp. 285-286.

down the social scale – the less exalted portions of the Empire’s officer corps and the lower reaches of its bureaucracy were full of men of peasant and priestly origin, and it was they, not the intellectuals and nobles of the center, who were the face of the Russian state, in Russian, but most particularly in non-Russian regions.²³ Etkind claims that his purpose in *Internal Colonization* is to explore Russia’s imperial *experience* – and for that, surely, one has to look beyond the literary, political, and philosophical canon, first of all to understand the reception of texts (an area in which postcolonial studies are in general very weak) and second, to write about less exalted genres: middlebrow stories in *Niva*, for example, or military travelogues. In this respect, the greatest lacuna in Etkind’s bibliography is the work of John MacKenzie on Orientalism, Imperialism, and Popular Culture, which mines these and other seams (theater, advertising, popular songs) in the cultural history of the British Empire.²⁴

In Etkind’s conclusion we return to the “overarching principle” of internal colonization, and to the cen-

tral problem with the book. To his credit, Etkind is not trying to make the case that internal colonization is another aspect of that well-worn historical trope, Russia’s *osobyi put’*. Citing Eugen Weber’s *Peasants into Frenchmen* (P. 254),²⁵ Etkind acknowledges that it can equally well be used to describe the nation-building enterprises of Germany or France, and their remaking of agrarian populations as citizens and workers. However, describing a state’s relationship to its titular nationality, however coercive, unequal, or alienating it might be, as “internal colonization,” makes “colonization” an almost universally applicable term and thus robs it of its usefulness.

The other problem is that Etkind never distinguishes satisfactorily between internal and external colonization. He writes:

The internal colonization of Russia was more equivalent to the British colonization of America than of India: non-Europeans were either assimilated or annihilated, leaving the empire to embark on colonization of its own people (P. 251).

²³ A. S. Morrison. *Russian Rule in Samarkand 1868–1910. A Comparison with British India*. Oxford, 2008. Pp. 126–166.

²⁴ John MacKenzie. *Propaganda and Empire. The Manipulation of British Public Opinion, 1880–1960*. Manchester, 1984. Pp. 18–19; Idem. *Orientalism. History, Theory and the Arts*. Manchester, 1995.

²⁵ Eugen Weber. *Peasants into Frenchmen. The Modernization of Rural France*. Stanford, 1976.

This statement is clearly untrue for many regions even of European Russia (Bashkiria, Kazan, Astrakhan) let alone the Central Asian steppe, Turkestan, or Transcaucasia, so the first question to ask is why the comparison has to be between India and America, two extremes of British imperialism, when Southern Africa and Algeria, colonies of settlement that nevertheless retained large indigenous populations, might work better as a point of analogy for Russian colonization? However, if we are supposed to take this statement as applicable only to “internal colonization,” then where does the boundary run? Is the Volga region, with its large (and surviving) Turkic population, an example of “internal” colonization while the Asian steppe is “external?” Or does internal colonization only refer to Russians, wherever they might happen to be? Leaving aside the question of how the latter should be defined (in Central Asia, for instance, it was “Europeanness” – Russian, Ukrainian, German – that was the truly salient category), this still renders Etkind’s statement baffling, as it suggests that either all the empire’s peoples became Russian (which was clearly not the case) or that the empire did

not colonize “its own people” (i.e., Russians) where they had colonized the lands of non-Russians who were neither assimilated nor annihilated (which makes no sense either), *or* that there is some clear geographical boundary that demarcates internal and external colonization (which would be impossible to draw). The logical, geographical, and historical confusion is profound. The emphasis on assimilation also carries unfortunate echoes of a persistent tradition of Slavophile imperial ideology, best exemplified by Nikolai Danilevskii, which saw Russian imperial expansion as an organic outgrowth of Russian statehood in which non-Russians were simply absorbed.²⁶

Etkind explicitly invokes Geoffrey Hosking’s argument that the Russians were the principal victims of their own empire (P. 26), partly because they were exploited to maintain it, but also because it stunted the growth of a Russian nation.²⁷ The latter part of Hosking’s argument seemed odd even when it first appeared in 1996: the Russians have at least as clear an idea of who they are as any other people in Europe, even if it is more difficult to point to the boundaries of unambiguously Russian territory, and the process of

²⁶ N. Ia. Danilevskii. *Rossiiia i Evropa. Vzgliad na kulturnye i politicheskie otnosheniia Slavianskogo mira k Germano-Romanskomu* [1871]. Moscow, 2003. Pp. 45-46; Maiorova. *From the Shadow of Empire*. Pp. 184-191.

²⁷ Geoffrey Hosking. *Russia, People and Empire. 1552-1917*. London, 1996; Idem. *Rulers and Victims. The Russians in the Soviet Union*. Cambridge, MA, 2006.

imagining the nation was already well under way among elements of the Russian intelligentsia in the 1840s and 1850s. Today, that sense of self has grown more aggressive and more exclusive, and, in common with many other modern nationalisms, is eager to bolster its moral claims by simultaneously laying claim to the status of great power and historical victim. Although this is clearly not his intention, Etkind's argument is unfortunately all too compatible with this view of Russian history.



Krista SIGLER

Дмитрий Чураков. Революция, государство, рабочий протест: формы, динамика и природа массовых выступлений рабочих в Советской России, 1917–1918 годы. Москва: Российская Политическая Энциклопедия (РОССПЭН), 2004. 366 с. ISBN: 5-8243-0423-8.

The idea of studying workers' political activity is not a new one for Western students of twentieth-century Russian and Soviet history. Nor has the topic been ignored in examinations of the Revolution. Indeed, the question of worker engagement in revolution—in the initial Revolution and through the Stalin era—has inspired works ranging from Alexander Rabinowich's extensive histories of the revolution to Sheila Fitzpatrick's efforts to understand the functioning of the later Stalinist society. But in *Revolutsiia, gosudarstvo, rabochii protest*, Dmitrii Churakov does indeed do something new from a Russian-language perspective. His study of the Revolution, especially 1917–1918, keeps its eyes trained firmly on the perspective of the workers, asking what their organization was like, to what extent they were under central orders from the Bolsheviks, differences across the former tsarist empire, and whether the workers had any alternatives to the Bolshevik